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**Original Page:** 208**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1950-1961**Coverage Date:** 1950-1961**Place Coverage:** Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana**Section Title(S)**Some General Principles Regarding Terms • The Joking Relationship

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The generational aspect of the pattern was not brought out by !Kung informants and did not become clear to me until I worked over the material. !Kung informants showed no interest in generation as such. What a !Kung says, when he associates his relatives with each other in the pattern I have called generational, is that they are "like" each other. He considers his parents' siblings to be "like" his parents, his sibling's offspring to be "like" his offspring, his cousins to be "like" himself. That they are alike because they occupy the same "step or stage in the succession of natural descent" (as Webster defines "generation") apparently does not concern the !Kung. Instead it was the joking relationship they spoke of, and they pointed out the parallel position of their kin in its terms.

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Joking is reciprocal; if ego jokes with A, A jokes with ego.

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In Figure 1,<sup>A</sup> the pattern of the joking relationship is shown.<sup>5</sup> A rectangle calls attention to the nuclear family. Throughout in ego's generation and in the first ascending and descending generations, the pattern of joking is parallel to the pattern in the nuclear family. Only among ego's lineal kin in the generation of great-grandparents, grandparents, grandchildren, great-grandchildren is the joking relation established by the generational method. To persons in those generations, other than lineal kin, the joking relationship would be determined through the name-relationship.

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### *Some General Principles Regarding Terms*

1. Terminologically, no two persons may be simultaneously interrelated in more than one way. Persons may change their terminological relationship by marriage or, under some circumstances, by having their names changed, but when this occurs the old terminological relationship is supplanted by the new.
2. The relative age of any two persons applying kin terms to each other is always recognized and indicated by means of the term used, except in a few instances among affines. Relative age is determined by  [p.209]

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Fig. 1. Ego's joking relationship

| 3 | 2 | 1 | Ego's  | 1      | 2 | 3 | Generation                                     |
|---|---|---|--------|--------|---|---|------------------------------------------------|
| I | + | I |        | I      | + | I | Lineal kin                                     |
|   |   |   | *<br>I | *<br>+ |   |   | Siblings                                       |
|   |   |   | *<br>I | *<br>+ |   |   | Spouses of siblings                            |
|   |   | I | +      | I      |   |   | Cousins,<br>uncles, aunts,<br>nephews, nieces  |
|   |   | I | +      | I      |   |   | Spouses of the latter                          |
|   |   |   | +      |        |   |   | Ego's spouse                                   |
|   |   |   |        | I      |   |   | Ego's spouse's parents                         |
|   |   | I | *<br>+ | *<br>I |   |   | Ego's spouse's siblings<br>and their offspring |
|   |   |   | *<br>+ | *<br>I |   |   | Spouses of ego's spouse's<br>siblings          |
|   |   |   |        | I      |   |   | Parents of the latter                          |
|   |   | I |        |        |   |   | Ego's offsprings' spouses                      |
|   |   |   | +      |        |   |   | Parents of the latter                          |

+ Joking allowed

I Joking prohibited

\* Same sex as ego

‡ Opposite sex from ego

No asterisk means no differentiation is made between sexes.

The rectangle calls attention to the kin in the nuclear family.

210 order of birth. The concept of relative age is inherent in the terms for father, mother, son, daughter, elder brother, elder sister, and younger sibling. In other instances, the term that the older person applies to the younger is a diminutive.

3. Unless it is specifically stated that the information given pertains only to a male ego or only to a female ego, it is to be assumed that it pertains to both.

4. The abbreviations "m.s." and "w.s." following the kin terms mean "a man is speaking" and "a woman is speaking." If no indication to the contrary is given, it is to be assumed that the term is the same, man-speaking and woman-speaking. (For the sake of avoiding possible ambiguities, I have occasionally used both abbreviations together—"m.s., w.s."—instead of simply omitting them.)

5. When I use English kin terms in my description of the !Kung system, these terms have their English meanings. Thus "grandparents" includes FaFa, MoFa,

FaMo, and MoMo. The terms “uncle” and “aunt” include siblings of both of ego’s parents and the spouses of those siblings. The !Kung make no distinction between paternal and maternal cousins, nor between cross and parallel cousins, so one can conveniently use the term “cousin” to include FaBrSo, FaBrDa, FaSiSo, FaSiDa, MoBrSo, MoBrDa, MoSiSo, MoSiDa. When I use the terms “nephew” and “niece” I include BrSo, SiSo, BrDa, SiDa.

6. If ego has the joking relationship with persons to whom he applies a given term, this will be indicated by *yes*; if not, by *no*. (The abbreviations “m.s.” and “w.s.” when used in reference to the joking relationship, have the same meanings as in paragraph 4 above.)

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A, [For Fig. 1, see Category 602, p. 209—Analyst]

5. James Fox, who kindly read this chapter, suggested the + - scheme and the general form of Fig. 1. I wish to express my thanks to him.

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